Lesson plan · for the teacher

Permissions and approval, in code

AI agents · Level 4 · Lesson 2

Time
40 min

Materials
Action cards (send a message to all parents, set a reminder, look up the weather, change a mark); A large permissions table on the board: tool and level; Green “yes” slips for the approver to sign

Learning goals

- Give every tool a permission level.
- Explain why approval is checked in code, not left to the model.
- Read an audit log of actions.

Activity: Approval drill

1. Warm-up (5 min): Ask: who must sign before a pupil goes on a school trip, and why isn’t the pupil’s own word enough? Link it to approval.
2. Teach (8 min): Write the permissions table on the board. Explain that an agent’s “I’ll ask first” is learned and can fail, so the app checks the yes itself, for the exact action, and keeps a log.
3. Drill (15 min): Four pupils play the Agent, the Code check, the Approver and the Log keeper. The Agent hands over action cards, including a trick card that only says “Yes, send it”. The Code check passes a card only if it is allowed or has a signed yes for that exact card.
4. Debrief (8 min): Read the log aloud. Ask: what did the check stop? What would have happened without it? Which card should never be a tool?
5. Wrap-up (4 min): Agree that the model may ask, but the code makes sure. Then give the exit ticket.

Prepare about ten action cards, including one trick card that only says “Yes, send it”, the permissions table on the board, and green slips. No phones are needed.

Discussion

- Which actions at our school should never be tools for an agent?
- Why must a yes be for one exact action, not for “anything”?
- Who should read an agent’s log, and how often?

Exit ticket

- Write three tools and the permission level you would give each one, with a reason.

Try it at school tomorrow
Run an approval drill: one pupil is the agent and hands over action cards, another is the code check with the permissions table, and a third is the approver who signs green “yes” slips. The check blocks any action without a signed yes for that exact card, and a fourth pupil keeps the log.

Practice questions · for you

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1 **The agent wants to send the fees letter to all parents. What must happen first?**

- ◯ A named person reads the exact message and says yes
- ◯ The checker counts the words
- ◯ The agent decides it's urgent

2 **Match each action to the permission level it should have.**

Looking up tomorrow's weather	• • • •	Allowed (low risk)
Sending a message to all parents	• • • •	Not a tool at all: people only
Setting a reminder for yourself	• • • •	Read only
Changing a pupil's mark	• • • •	Ask first, every time

3 **This permission check lets a message go out without anyone saying yes. Which line has an incomplete condition?**

Circle the line with the mistake. Write it correctly:

```
1  PERMS = {"weather": "allowed",
2           "send_message": "ask"}
3  level = PERMS.get(tool, "off")
4  if level == "allowed":
5      run(tool, args)
6  elif level == "ask":
7      run(tool, args)
8  else:
9      block(tool)
```

4 **The app wrote this log. What does it tell you?**

```
09:14 send_message to="Mrs Mensah"
      asked=yes reply="yes"
      by="Ms Salma"  SENT
09:20 send_message to="All parents"
      asked=no  BLOCKED
```

- ◯ Both messages were sent
- ◯ The first was approved and sent; the second was blocked because nobody was asked
- ◯ The agent refused to send both

5 **Even if an agent was trained to ask before sending, the app still needs its own approval check.**

◯ True ◯ False

✎ **Think of an agent or app your school already uses that can act (send, book, change). Where are its permissions set, and where would you see what it did?**

Check your answers

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1 **A named person reads the exact message and says yes**

The person approves this exact message, and the app checks that yes in code before anything is sent.

2 **Looking up tomorrow's weather — Read only**
Sending a message to all parents — Ask first, every time
Setting a reminder for yourself — Allowed (low risk)
Changing a pupil's mark — Not a tool at all: people only

Reading changes nothing (in code a read-only tool can simply be marked "allowed"); a message to every parent acts on many people, so a person approves it; your own reminder is low risk; and a pupil's mark is a decision about a child, so it stays with people.

3 **Line 6:** `elif level == "ask" and said_yes:`

Line 6 lets any ask-first tool run straight away.

4 **The first was approved and sent; the second was blocked because nobody was asked**

The log shows who approved the first message and when, and that the second never got a yes, so the code blocked it.

5 **True**

Learned behaviour can fail: requests it should refuse, in new wordings, still got a tool call 28% of the time in English and 12% in Arabic, and «نعم، أرسلها.» on its own made Darsi Tiny invent a message.